

« Impact Player rule is quite confusing; shifts focus from 11 players »

SAM CURRAN

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England's Sam Curran is highly valued in global franchise leagues for his all-round skills. Despite a challenging season as captain for Punjab Kings in this year's IPL — PBKS didn't reach the playoffs for the 10th season in a row — the 25-year-old remains optimistic.

The 2022 T20 World Cup Player of the Tournament shares his thoughts on England's prospects in the upcoming ICC event and discusses the Impact Player rule in the IPL with *Sportstar*.

You took over the reins from injured Shikhar Dhawan midway through this IPL season. How do you sum up your team's campaign?

Taking over halfway was always going to be a challenge, but I think it was an experience I didn't want to turn down. Unfortunately, the results haven't been what we would have liked. But we played some excellent cricket in patches. We just haven't got those close points you need. Overall, it was a very frustrating result, but you always have to look at the positives when you are losing.

You have to make sure you keep getting better at those things. The

group has been fantastic, and the energy in the camp has been really good.

When you look back and reflect, is there anything that you could have done differently?

That reflection will probably be done sometime after the tournament, but hindsight is a fantastic thing. You always look back and think, 'Oh, I wish we had done that.'

We batted well in some games, and we bowled well in others. But we just haven't put those perfect few games together with the bat, ball, and field.

But that's the sport. That's why we play this great game where you learn from losses, and take confidence from good performances. I always like to look forward.

How much has the IPL changed over the last couple of years with the Impact Player rule?

I guess the fans and people watching at home would love to just keep seeing lots of sixes, but I think the Impact Player rule has made a huge difference. With the bat, it allows players to go fractionally more attacking at the top of the order because they know if it doesn't

go to plan, you are most likely to just bring in that extra batter at No. 7 or 8. In a way, it has probably helped the scores and how the players are playing, but vice versa, if you bat well, it allows an extra bowler to be in when you are defending. So, there are pros and cons for each team. I think it does make it quite confusing, as it shifts the focus from 11 players and requires more tactical analysis. The rule has been here for a couple of seasons. Who knows what they will do with it? But it certainly has increased the scoring. The way batsmen are developing has been fantastic to watch, but the challenge of keeping it fair between the bat and the ball will always be a debate.

Since the game seems tilted towards the batters now, how does a bowler approach tricky situations?

You've got to watch the batsmen. They are finding different ways to attack the bowlers. The grounds in India offer some really good batting wickets. There's also the dew factor. As bowlers, you've got to keep challenging yourself in training. You need to start experimenting with different kinds of deliveries. You want to be in those moments —defending totals for your team. It